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‘Government’s Little Gain, People’s Great Loss’

PURSHOTAMDAS RETURNED TO INDIA SOMETHING of a hero. Barring a few Anglo-Indian newspapers, the Indian press lauded his valiant championing of the country’s cause. He continued his crusade on his return and attempted to rouse the people to a sense of their wrongs. He addressed meetings all over India and explained the importance of the issues involved and how the country’s interest was being hurt by a 1s 6d ratio. He was anxious that the average citizen and not just the intelligentsia understood the issues. Even an evangelist would have been pleased with his hot gospelling campaign against the 1s 6d ratio.

It was at one of these meetings—a garden party organized by prominent industrialists in which, among others, Sir Dorab Tata, Sir Victor Sassoon, and Sir Dinshaw Petit were present—that the Indian Currency League was set up to develop public interest in the currency problem, mobilize public opinion for a gold standard, and to oppose the move to peg the rupee at 1s 6d. The Currency League set up branches all over the country and meetings were held in different towns and cities where pamphlets, leaflets, and newsletters were distributed. Purshotamdas’s Minute was translated into regional languages, particularly Hindi, so that the Marwari community could get an idea of how the higher rate hurt Indian interests. Speaking at the inauguration of an educative campaign of the Currency League at Poona, Purshotamdas spoke at length on the ruinous policy of the government and termed it as ‘government’s little gain, people’s great loss.’[1]

VIGOROUS CAMPAIGN